

NYC Restaurant Inspection Results

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Dataset: DOHMH_New_York_City_Restaurant_Inspection_Results_20260630

Tool: DB Browser (SQLite)

FINDING 1 - GRADED INSPECTION TYPE

The NYC Restaurant Inspection Results show more than 50% of GRADE as NULL, meaning not every inspection gives out a grade. Initially assumed this meant only Cycle Inspections receive grades, but breaking down the inspection types showed otherwise. Data shows that 40.62% of graded inspections are **Cycle Inspection / Initial Inspection**, while **Cycle Inspection / Re-Inspection** comes close at 38.2%. Pre-Permit inspections come 3rd and 4th with **Pre-permit (Operational) / Initial Inspection** at 12.08% and **Pre-permit (Operational) / Re-inspection** at 7.1%.

Business Implication: Pre-opening of a business comes with an inspection, and a cycle inspection is done post-opening. Reasons behind the frequency of re-inspections will be investigated in a later finding.

FINDING 2 - PERCENTAGE OF GRADE GIVEN

There are 3 main grade types for restaurants: **A**, **B** and **C**. **A** graded restaurants lead with 67.54%, **B** grade comes second with 12.53%, while **C** grade comes third with 9.05%. **N**, **Z**, and **P** grades come after respectively. It is worth noting that **N** (at 7.03%) is for restaurants **Not Yet Graded**, while **Z** (at 3.28%) and **P** (at 0.57%) are for **Grade Pending**, **Z** being the worst possible as it stands for violation issues, hence the pending grade.

Business Implication: The A grade, which is the best score a restaurant can get, is given generously, meaning if a business is given a B or C, it can only mean that a restaurant's quality is degrading and should raise an immediate question on how to improve and what establishments are lagging behind on maintenance.

FINDING 3 - B AND C GRADE PERCENTAGE PER CUISINE

As established in Finding 2, an A grade is generally given, considering an establishment should operate at its best shape. The purpose of this finding is to see how much a B and C grade is given relative to cuisine description, to identify the restaurants that are failing to meet the standard.

Creole tops the B&C grade rate list with 59.77%, followed by **Bangladeshi** with 49.12%, and **Pakistani** with 45.98%. It is worth noting that these are lower-volume cuisine types, meaning a small number of non-compliant establishments can significantly skew the rate. Sample size should be considered when interpreting these figures.

Business Implication: Restaurant owners and health consultancy clients operating under these cuisine types should be made aware that they carry a higher-than-average risk of receiving a substandard grade during inspections. Extra precaution around sanitation practices, equipment maintenance, and food handling procedures is strongly advised to avoid compliance issues before the next inspection cycle.

FINDING 4 - B AND C GRADE PERCENTAGE PER BOROUGH

Now taking a look at the grades per borough — **Queens** leads with the highest B&C grade rate at 25.29%, followed by the **Bronx** at 23.65%, **Brooklyn** at 20.98%, **Manhattan** at 19.33%, and **Staten Island** at 18.36%.

It is worth noting that **Manhattan**, despite having the largest sample size surpassing 50,000 inspections, maintains the second lowest failure rate, a strong signal that restaurants in the city's core are held to and meeting a higher standard, as **Manhattan** represents how the city is viewed in terms of restaurant quality by tourists and visitors alike. The **Bronx**, on the other hand, carries the second highest failure rate with only 13,000+ inspections, which raises a question about what specific violation types are driving non-compliance in that borough, a thread worth investigating in a later finding.

Business Implication: Aspiring business owners in **Queens** and the **Bronx** should be particularly aware of the higher compliance risk in those boroughs and invest accordingly in equipment maintenance and sanitation practices. Businesses operating in **Manhattan** are setting the standard correctly, but the pressure to maintain that standard remains high given the borough's outsized role in shaping the city's reputation for dining quality.

FINDING 5 - MOST COMMON VIOLATION CITY-WIDE

Looking at the top violations on a city-wide level, the first which is "**Non-food contact surface or equipment made of unacceptable material, not kept clean, or not properly sealed, raised, spaced or movable to allow accessibility for cleaning on all sides, above and underneath the unit**", and the third is "**Food contact surface not properly washed, rinsed and sanitized after each use and following any activity when contamination may have occurred**", it is a clear cleanliness issue, which combined comes up to **20.3%** of the violations already. Cleanliness is the most basic, yet most overlooked thing, which is easily avoidable.

The second top violation is "**Establishment is not free of harborage or conditions conducive to rodents, insects or other pests**", which comes up to **8.53%**. It is a well known issue citywide that NYC has a terrible rodent problem, and restaurants are expected to treat this issue very seriously as it is scrutinized heavily by inspectors.

Business Implication: Focus on the most important and obvious core values a restaurant must have, which is cleanliness and maintaining it, and an establishment should have

already cleared most of its concerns about earning a grade B and below. Investing in pest control, cleaning guidelines, and proper staff training should be enough to pass the standard.

FINDING 6 - HIGHEST RODENT AND PEST-RELATED VIOLATION RATE PER BOROUGH

The citywide problem with rodents and pests is observable across all five boroughs, but the **Bronx** stands out. Despite ranking fourth out of five in sample size, it tops the pest violation rate in the city at **9.7%**, raising an alarming question as to the preparedness to combat this issue in that borough. **Manhattan**, despite having the largest sample size, ranks last at 8.49%, reflecting the higher preparedness standards expected of the city's core. It is worth noting however that the gap between first and last is only **1.2** percentage points, suggesting this is a citywide issue rather than one isolated to any single borough.

Business Implication: If a business is to be started in the **Bronx** area, it is heavily advised to consult an expert on rodent and pest control, as the numbers indicate it is a more acute problem there relative to the rest of the city. Regardless of borough, pest prevention should be treated as a baseline operational requirement for any new restaurant.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This analysis examined over 290,000 inspection records across New York City's five boroughs using SQL, with the goal of understanding how restaurants perform against the city's health and safety standards. The findings reveal that despite an A grade being the only acceptable standard for establishments serving food for human consumption, only 67.54% of graded inspections result in an A, a number that should be higher. Cleanliness and pest-related violations together account for roughly 28% of all citywide violations, representing the most preventable and recurring compliance failures across all boroughs. While Manhattan demonstrates stronger compliance relative to its size, the Bronx consistently surfaces as the borough most at risk, particularly around pest control, a thread that runs through multiple findings in this analysis.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. **Aim for the highest grade (A).** It is the most commonly given grade and should be the goal for any starting or existing business. Falling below an A is not a middle ground. It is a signal that something fundamental needs immediate attention.
2. **Prepare for the Cycle Inspection.** The two most common graded inspections are the Initial Inspection and the Re-inspection. A re-inspection is conducted when the initial inspection reveals unresolved violations, meaning preparation before the first visit is always the better strategy.
3. **Be aware of your cuisine's compliance history.** As found in this analysis, Creole, Bangladeshi, and Pakistani cuisines are among the top B and C grade earners.

Establishments under these cuisine types should take extra precaution with workplace cleanliness and equipment maintenance before inspection cycles.

4. **Know your borough's main issue before opening.** The Bronx leads all boroughs in pest and rodent-related violation rates and should serve as an early warning for any establishment planning to open there. Investing in professional pest control before the first inspection is strongly advised.
5. **Treat cleanliness as a non-negotiable baseline.** Roughly 28% of all citywide violations are cleanliness and pest-related — the most preventable category. Proper staff training, cleaning schedules, and equipment maintenance alone would eliminate the majority of violations seen in this dataset.